The Joy Mechanism: A Hypothesis You Can Test

A mechanism can be testable, coherent, and useful, yet remain unexamined when it falls outside institutional pathways.

This document addresses that gap by proposing a directly testable hypothesis of joy, developed independently and open to critique and transmission.

It does not ask for belief, but for evaluation of the mechanism itself.

Rather than framing joy in terms of reward or learning, this document develops an alternative grounded **in control dynamics.**

Author: Florian Morin. FlorianMorin.com

A central implication of this model is that real-time attempts to measure or optimize the state may suppress the very phenomenon they aim to produce. The following section introduces a minimal formalization of the mechanism.

Computational Formalization of joy

Don't worry about this math section. Go to the game-task directly if you do not care about it.

Let $\delta(t)$ denote prediction error. Discrepancies are transformed into corrective drives:

$c(t) = g \cdot \delta(t)$ with evaluative gain: $g = g_0 + \alpha \cdot Z(t)$

A regime transition occurs at g^*:

- $g \geq g^* \rightarrow$ rapid correction
- $g < g^* \rightarrow$ persistent discrepancy

In the decoupled regime: ,$\delta\_eff(t) = \int_0^t \delta(\tau)\, w(\tau)\, d\tau$, $I(t) \propto \delta\_eff(t)$

Z controls evaluative load, and g maps prediction error signals to correction. Reducing Z weakens this mapping, allowing discrepancies to persist **as signals rather than corrections** and drive intensity.

Game-task (FPS, HUD off, e.g., Quake or Unreal Tournament), called "M-ZRT" for "Morin Z-Reduction task".

A first-person game with the HUD removed reduces continuous evaluative feedback. When competitive optimization is locally suspended, action is no longer guided by performance monitoring or goal correction. The player can retain immediate control and perceptual intensity while evaluative load (Z) is reduced.

The effect follows an inverted U-shape with respect to evaluative load (Z): brief, non-instrumental perturbations reduce Z by weakening monitoring, whereas repetition reintroduces anticipation, comparison, and checking, increasing Z and reinstating monitoring. The aim is to reduce optimization, not to replace it.

*Seconds fix what minutes and hours destroy***.** U-shaped effect, as repetition re-introduce evaluation, anticipation, checking, and optimization.

Within the game-task:

Exercise	**Operation**	**Z**	**g**	**δ**	**Mechanism**
Deviate trajectory	While moving toward a direction, you briefly deviate course for an instant	↓	↓	introduced + persists	disrupts trajectory optimization and prevents immediate correction
Micro-movement	You perform a small, purposeless gesture (eg: random shoulders moves) and do not follow up	↓ (slight)	↓	introduced	creates a minimal discrepancy without triggering a goal-directed response
Incomplete question	Ask an incomplete or meaningless question (e.g., “what if?”) but you do not attempt to answer or resolve it	↓	↓	persists	prevents cognitive closure and blocks conversion into problem-solving
Fading image	Make a mental image, you notice when it fades away	↓	↓	amplified	leverages transient salience without stabilizing it through control
Suspension phrases	You use one phrase like “nothing to figure out right now”, "this is a procedure", or "It's fine if nothing happens”	↓	↓	persists	reduces closure pressure without introducing a new objective
Alcohol (very low dose; a sip)	A small dose reduces control and monitoring globally	↓	↓	persists (+ noise)	lowers evaluative load but may reduce signal coherence
Forme géométrique	Notice a geometric shape of the décor, corner, corridor, ramp, pillar, void, without trying to interpret it.	↓ (light)	↓	amplified	perceptual salience without semanticization
Coffee (very low dose, a sip)	Increased arousal raises sensitivity to incoming signals	~ / ↑	~ / ↑	↑	increases δ without necessarily reducing Z

These exercises fall into three functional classes, salience (perceptual prominence), openness, and suspension. Many combine multiple mechanisms, such as amplifying a signal while preventing its resolution or interrupting ongoing optimization.

Use up to three items from the table, vary their order each day, and randomly alternate between coffee, nothing, and alcohol. Recommended: not more than 1 attempt at the game-task for every 24h.

After the game-task

Exercise	**Operation**	**Z**	**g**	**δ**	**Mechanism**
Simple faces	Faces images with low complexity (e.g., children, clear expressions) that require little inference	↓↓	↓↓	amplified	reduces evaluative load by minimizing social decoding
Jewels	You observe highly saturated, reflective images (e.g., gemstones) without assigning meaning or use	↓↓	↓↓	amplified	combines high perceptual intensity with minimal interpretative demand

Type of optimization:

• Reward optimization – trying to reach, prolong, or maximize a “good” moment
• Outcome optimization – acting to obtain a specific result
• Continuity optimization – following sequences to completion
• **Attention optimization** – maintaining focus deliberately
• Understanding optimization – trying to make sense or extract meaning
• **Self-evaluation optimization** – checking whether one is doing it correctly

These dimensions are provided only as a retrospective framework to recognize where optimization may have occurred. They are not intended to be applied, monitored, or used to guide behavior.

Walking as Low Decision-Pressure Activity

Walking provides a natural context to reduce evaluative load when action is decoupled from selection, optimization, and symbolic meaning. If you think about going out, do not choose a place for a specific reason or preference.

Non-special route
At times, take a path that is not meaningful, not the nicest, not the most promising.
Goal: avoid selecting the environment as a “source” of the state.
Change sidewalk without reason
You switch sides of the street arbitrarily, without justification.
Effect: disrupts path optimization and weakens directional control.
Brief stop and restart
You stop for 1–2 seconds, then resume walking without compensating or explaining the interruption.
Effect: interrupts action continuity without restoring optimization.

Evaluative load increases when behavior becomes goal-directed, monitored, compared, optimized, or constrained by expected outcomes. It decreases when these processes are locally suspended:

Music should remain for as a background than searching for the right song or moment

Fragmented reading, shifting between paragraphs from different books, disrupts narrative continuity and prevents integration.

In general, act without explaining or justifying what you do, internally or externally. Do not defend internal states. Consider any activity, including this one, as a procedure with no particular meaning. Do not frame your actions as part of a meaningful process. There is nothing to achieve, nothing to improve, and nothing to check.

> **Inverted U: minimal use ↓Z, routinized use ↑Z. The goal is to reduce optimization, not to create a new one.** *Seconds fix what minutes and hours destroy.*

If you feel like it, you can send the questionnaire to me at florian@florianmorin.com, no pressure at all.
Yes/No

1. I felt less need to decide what to do next.
2. I felt less need to correct or adjust my actions.
3. Something felt unexpectedly more vivid, pleasant, or engaging.
4. Any change felt sudden rather than gradual.
5. I could not identify a clear cause for any change.
6. The task became a method or strategy.

free-text question: **In a few sentences, describe what happened, especially whether anything felt different, sudden, vivid, pleasant, effortless, or strange.**